

EUGAEA

Working Title | Game Concept Pitch Document | Confidential

"A world without end. A story without limits."

Genre	High Fantasy / Steampunk — Medieval Planetary World
Format	Narrative RPG — single-player core; multiplayer as future layer
Tone	Dark & morally complex — no clear good or evil
Death	Permanent — character story ends on death
Stage	Concept / Pre-production — Writing Phase
Document	Quick Pitch · Part I: Core Design · Part II: Multiplayer · Part III: Ideas & Issues

QUICK PITCH

One page. Everything you need to know.

WHAT IS EUGAEA?

Eugaea is a high fantasy, steampunk, souls-like world where every character has a story, and every player writes a different one.

You do not create a character. You step into one — a hero, a human, a villain, a creature, an entity. Each has their own life, goals, secrets, and a place in the same vast world. Some characters will meet. Some will never cross paths. Some will be enemies. The world they share is the same. The journey through it is never the same twice.

THE CORE LOOP

- **Start random.** Your first character is chosen for you — matched to your instinctive play style. From there, you choose.
- **Switch to survive.** Characters don't grind endlessly. When you hit a wall — a boss traps you, an area locks you out, a storyline stalls — you switch to a new character and advance the world from a different angle.
- **Death is absolute.** If a character dies, their story ends. Forever. Their goals, their unfinished business, their relationships — left behind for other characters to inherit, ignore, or stumble upon.
- **The world remembers.** Every decision changes the world every other character inhabits. Play as a king and shape a war. Play as a thief in that same war. Both experiences exist in the same Eugaea.
- **The story never ends.** The creator builds the world and its original cast. The community expands it — new areas, new characters, new stories — all reviewed and published into canon. Eugaea grows as long as people care about it.
- **Built for one, open to many.** Eugaea is a single-player experience at heart. Multiplayer — where two different characters meet and share a story moment — is a future layer that deepens the world without replacing the solo journey.

IN ONE SENTENCE

A deep, dark, living world of medieval fantasy and steam-age invention — where every character has a story, every death is final, every choice echoes, and the world never stops growing.

Genre	High Fantasy + Steampunk, Souls-like difficulty and consequence
Perspective	Single-player narrative RPG — designed characters, not player avatars
Tone	Dark, morally complex — no clear heroes or villains
Death	Permanent — character story ends; consequences persist in the world

Growth	Community-expandable world with creator-reviewed canon publishing
Visual style	TBD — 2D retro or 3D AAA; decision pending pre-production scoping

PART I

THE GAME PITCH

1. The Vision

Eugaea is a living, breathing world — not a game with a story, but a world that contains stories. Players step into a designed character, live their life, make their choices, and experience a narrative shaped entirely by how they play. Death is final. The world remembers everything. The story never truly ends — because the community keeps building it.

2. The World of Eugaea

Eugaea is a planet — vast enough to feel infinite, designed enough to feel intentional. Its age is ancient. Its civilisations are layered. Its history is written in stone, steam, and blood.

Setting

The world sits at the intersection of medieval fantasy and early steampunk. Magic is real but poorly understood — predating recorded history and interpreted differently by every culture. Some kingdoms are feudal, bound by sword and faith. Others have industrialised — burning alchemical coal to power printing presses, rail-carts, and mechanical war-machines. Magic and machine co-exist uneasily. The tension between the ancient and the invented is one of Eugaea's defining conflicts.

Geography & scale

The world is planetary in scale but designed at the human level. The creator defines regions — each with its own culture, biome, political situation, and secrets — that together form a coherent, interconnected world. Not every region is accessible to every character. Some areas are locked behind story, knowledge, or trust. A select few only unlock when two characters meet in multiplayer.

Tone

Eugaea is morally complex. There are no chosen heroes and no great evil to defeat. Power is corrupt in ways both obvious and invisible. Loyalty is tested. History is rewritten by the victorious. Every decision costs something — and the world remembers the cost.

3. Core Game Mechanics

The random start

Players do not choose their first character. The game observes the player's instinctive decisions in a brief opening sequence and assigns a starting character whose play style, skills, and world position

match what it sees. This is not a restriction — it is an introduction. The world chooses you before you choose the world.

After the first character is established, players gain the ability to switch to new characters as the game progresses. The full roster opens gradually — each character discovered through play, not a menu.

The switch imperative

Characters are not meant to be played indefinitely in sequence without interruption. The world is designed so that every character eventually reaches a threshold — a point where progression stalls without the intervention of another perspective.

This may take the form of:

- **Imprisonment or capture.** After losing to a powerful enemy, the character is not killed — they are trapped. Rescue comes through another character's story.
- **Area locks.** Certain regions require specific knowledge, trust, or abilities that only different characters possess. You cannot force your way in as the wrong person.
- **Storyline stalls.** Some narrative threads cannot be resolved by the character who started them. They must be picked up by another.
- **Skill ceilings.** A character's progression reaches a natural limit determined by who they are. Growing beyond it requires experiencing a different kind of power.

Switching is not a penalty. It is the game working as designed. The world is too large and too complex for any one person to navigate alone.

Death is absolute

When a character dies, their story ends. Not pauses — ends. There is no respawn. There is no retry from the last save. The character's goals, relationships, unresolved threads, and unclaimed secrets remain in the world — available to other characters to find, inherit, or never encounter. A dead character becomes part of Eugaea's history.

Death is designed to be rare. The world does not kill casually. Most dangerous encounters result in capture, entrapment, or setback — not death. But the possibility of death is real, and that weight is felt in every decision.

When a character does die, the world changes. NPCs react. Stories shift. Other characters may encounter the aftermath — a grave, a legend, a warning, a vacancy someone else must fill.

Character entities — who you can be

Playable characters in Eugaea are not restricted to human heroes. The roster may include:

- **Heroes & protagonists.** Characters with clear moral purpose and a story of struggle toward something worth believing in
- **Villains & antagonists.** Characters whose goals are in direct conflict with others — including other playable characters
- **Monsters & creatures.** Non-human entities with their own intelligence, culture, and place in the world's ecology
- **Factions & institutions.** Characters who embody or lead larger forces — a general, a cult leader, a guild master

- **The forgotten.** Ordinary people caught in extraordinary events — characters whose stories matter precisely because they were never supposed to

Some character types will never cross paths. Some will meet as opponents — forcing the player to choose which side of a conflict they occupy. The same world event can be a triumph from one character's perspective and a catastrophe from another's.

Each character is distinct

Every playable character starts in a different part of the world with a different social position, different skills, and a different relationship to Eugaea's factions and powers. Core game mechanics — exploration, combat, dialogue, puzzle-solving — are shared across all characters, but each character has unique implementations:

- **Combat style.** A soldier fights with discipline and force. A mage with precision and cost. A creature with instinct. A trickster with misdirection.
- **Dialogue access.** Characters speak to the world differently. Some doors open with words. Others open with reputation. Others with fear.
- **World knowledge.** What your character knows shapes what you see. A scholar reads environmental details an assassin misses. A monster perceives threats invisible to a human.
- **Starting conditions.** Each character begins in a location suited to their story — some in positions of power, some in desperation, some in ignorance of how significant they will become.

4. The Character System

The character roster is the world's cast. The creator designs the initial set — each a complete person with a history, a place in Eugaea, and a story that intersects with the larger world in its own way. The roster is not announced upfront; it is discovered through play.

Cross-character consequences

The order in which characters are played changes the world they inhabit. An event resolved by one character — a war ended, a tyrant removed, a secret revealed — alters the conditions of every subsequent character's story. A character played early sets the world in motion for those played later. A character played last inherits the consequences of everything that came before.

This is not a fixed domino chain. Players can choose any character at any time. The world adapts — not by forcing a single timeline, but by making every order of play feel coherent and intentional.

The dead character as world artifact

When a character dies, they do not disappear. They become part of the world's record. Other characters may find their belongings, encounter people who knew them, hear stories of what they did or failed to do. A player who loses a character early may encounter the ghost of their choices when playing a completely different character much later.

5. The Community Expansion Layer

Eugaea is built to grow beyond its creator. The community expansion layer is the mechanism by which the world deepens over time without losing coherence.

- **Tools.** Community developers access a dedicated SDK and world-building toolkit
- **Scope.** They may add new areas, characters, storylines, bosses, factions, lore, or playable characters — all within the world's established rules
- **Community review.** Submitted content is visible to the community, who can play and rate it
- **Creator gate.** The creator reviews top-rated submissions and officially publishes the best into the canon world
- **Canon integration.** Published content is permanent — it becomes part of Eugaea, experienced by all future players without any opt-in required

This is the distinction that separates Eugaea from a modded game: approved community content is not optional or unofficial. It is the world. Players do not choose to install it. They encounter it as they would anything else in Eugaea — because it is.

Note: The community expansion layer and multiplayer are scoped as future implementations. The primary focus of the initial release is a complete, high-quality single-player experience. Community tools and multiplayer will be developed once the core world is stable.

6. AI Integration

Artificial intelligence is built into Eugaea as a core infrastructure layer — not a feature, not a gimmick. It is what makes the scale of this world manageable.

AI-powered NPC behaviour

NPCs are not scripted automatons. They have context — they know what your character has done, said, and represented. A character who was witnessed betraying an ally will not receive warm greetings from those who heard about it. A faction that has heard of your reputation will react before you speak. AI allows the world's inhabitants to respond to the specific state of your journey.

Adaptive narrative

The AI tracks the web of choices a player has made and surfaces consequences, callbacks, and opportunities coherent with their specific history. A decision made early in a playthrough can resurface much later — not as a scripted trigger, but as a living consequence in a world that remembers.

Death consequence generation

When a character dies, the AI assists in generating appropriate world responses — NPC dialogue that acknowledges the absence, narrative adjustments that reflect what the character left unfinished, and subtle environmental signals that the world has changed. Death is not a loading screen. It is an event the world processes.

Community content consistency

When community content is submitted or integrated, AI tools assist in checking for lore consistency, flagging contradictions with established canon, and suggesting how new content can connect to existing storylines. This reduces the review burden on the creator and maintains world coherence as the content library grows.

7. Gameplay & Player Experience

Eugaea is a story-first game with souls-like consequence. Its closest relatives are Elden Ring, the Witcher series, and God of War — games where world and character are inseparable. But Eugaea extends this: every character is a different lens on the same world, and the world is shaped by every lens applied to it.

Exploration	Open but not empty. Each character unlocks different paths, regions, and knowledge. Some areas require specific characters. Some require switching to have already happened.
Combat	Souls-like in consequence — death is final, encounters demand attention. Each character has a distinct combat system rooted in their background and nature.
Decisions	Permanent within a playthrough. The world records them. Some choices affect other characters' worlds. None can be taken back.
Puzzles & mystery	The world is full of things that can only be understood from specific character perspectives. A puzzle solved by one character may recontextualise something another character experienced earlier.
Character switch	Not a menu option but a world event. Switching has narrative framing — the current character reaches a threshold, and the transition acknowledges it.
Endings	Each character has multiple possible endings shaped by decisions, the order of play, and what other characters have done before them. Some endings are only possible if a specific character is still alive.

8. Visual Design Direction — Decision Pending

The visual direction of Eugaea has not yet been finalised. Two viable paths are under consideration, each with significant implications for scope, budget, and the kind of experience the game delivers.

Option A 2D Retro	Pixel art or hand-drawn 2D style. Lower production cost per asset. Easier to expand — community content can be created without AAA tooling. Strong creative precedent (Hollow Knight, Hades, Disco Elysium). Allows more resources to go into narrative depth, world design, and systems. Risk: perceived as lower ambition by some audiences.
Option B 3D AAA	Full 3D with realistic or stylised rendering. Maximum immersion and visual storytelling capacity. Higher production cost per asset and per expansion. Community content creation requires more technical expertise. Strong market precedent (Elden Ring, Witcher 3). Risk: scope and budget demands could compromise depth of world design and systems.

Recommendation: This decision should be made before pre-production begins, as it determines every downstream decision about team size, tooling, asset pipeline, and community SDK design. Neither path is wrong — but the choice is foundational and cannot be easily reversed.

9. Market Position

Eugaea sits at the intersection of three proven markets — none of which has produced what Eugaea proposes to be.

Narrative RPGs	God of War, Elden Ring, Witcher 3 — proven audience for deep, character-driven worlds. Eugaea adds multi-character depth, permanent death, and community scale.
Community platforms	Minecraft, Roblox, Neverwinter Nights — proven appetite for player-created worlds. Eugaea adds authorial quality, canon control, and narrative coherence.
Souls-like games	Elden Ring, Dark Souls, Hollow Knight — proven audience for worlds where death carries weight and exploration is its own reward. Eugaea makes death narratively permanent rather than mechanically punishing.

The gap Eugaea fills: a single-player, story-quality experience built on permanent consequence, a multi-character world that grows through community authorship, and a souls-like respect for the player's intelligence. No game currently offers all three simultaneously.

PART II

MULTIPLAYER DESIGN

Note: Multiplayer is scoped as a future implementation layer. The initial release of Eugaea is a complete single-player experience. The design below establishes the multiplayer framework so it can be built into the world's architecture from the start — avoiding costly retrofitting later.

Multiplayer in Eugaea is not a mode. It is a narrative feature — an extension of the world's core idea that different characters experience the same world differently. When two characters meet, the world changes again.

1. Multiplayer Principles

Same character restriction

Two players cannot play as the same character in a multiplayer session. Characters are individuals — two versions of the same person cannot coexist in the same world at the same time. This is a hard rule that protects narrative integrity and prevents identity contradiction.

Future possibility: a separate dedicated storyline within the world could explore what happens when two iterations of the same character meet — a parallel timeline, a fracture event, or a world anomaly. This is not in scope for the initial release but is a viable long-term expansion concept worth preserving design space for.

Multiplayer as story, not just co-op

When Player 1 (playing Character A) invites Player 2 (playing Character B), their meeting is not a gameplay event bolted onto the world — it is a narrative event within it. Characters A and B inhabit the same Eugaea. Their meeting has story consequences. New plot beats emerge that neither character's solo arc would generate. The world acknowledges that these two people found each other.

The world invitation model

Rather than a shared server or lobby, Eugaea uses a world invitation system. One player invites another into their active world session. The visiting player's world state is temporarily synchronised with the host's — they share a moment of the world, not a permanent merge. When the session ends, both players return to their own world states, carrying the consequences of what they did together.

2. Session Structure

How a session begins

- **Host.** Player 1 extends an invitation from within their active world session

- **Join condition.** Player 2 must be playing a different character — enforced at the invitation stage
- **Entry point.** Player 2 enters the host's world at a story-appropriate location that makes narrative sense for their character to appear
- **Sync.** The session synchronises both players' shared world context: location, active quests, faction states relevant to the current area

What happens during a session

- **Quests.** Players can assist each other on active quests. Some quests have multiplayer variants — additional objectives, dialogue, or outcomes that only trigger when both characters are present
- **Locked areas.** Certain areas of Eugaea are only accessible when two specific characters (or character types) meet. These cannot be reached solo
- **Story beats.** The characters meeting generates new narrative context — dialogue, NPC reactions, and events acknowledging both characters are present. Some become permanent entries in each player's story
- **Combat.** Both characters fight together. Their combined abilities create interactions unique to that specific character pairing — designed synergies, not generic co-op

Session limits

The maximum number of simultaneous players, session length limits, and whether more than two characters can share a session are design decisions still to be finalised. The initial framework assumes two players as the core multiplayer unit, with the option to expand to larger groups in later design phases.

3. The Knowledge Bleed Problem

This is the most nuanced design challenge in Eugaea's multiplayer system, and it must be addressed directly.

The problem

If Player 1 plays as Character A and, during a multiplayer session, spends significant time with Character B (played by Player 2), Player 1 gains substantial knowledge of Character B's world, personality, relationships, and story. When Player 1 later chooses to play as Character B solo, that knowledge already exists. B's story — its reveals, its surprises, its emotional arc — is partially spoiled.

The proposed solution — Shared Story Recognition

When a player has experienced significant portions of a character's story through multiplayer, the game recognises this and adjusts that character's solo playthrough accordingly. Story beats already witnessed are acknowledged rather than re-played — B's world reflects that certain things have already happened between the two characters. The solo playthrough is shorter in those respects, but not lesser: it reframes the already-known events from B's internal perspective, adding emotional depth rather than repeating plot.

In practical terms:

- **Acknowledged.** Quests and story beats witnessed during the multiplayer session are marked as shared history rather than new discovery
- **Reframed.** B's solo story explores what those same events meant to B — thoughts, feelings, and decisions the player did not see from A's perspective
- **Preserved.** Story content never witnessed during the A+B session remains fully intact and plays normally
- **Player choice.** The player is informed before starting B's solo run that they have shared history with B, and can choose how much of the reframed content they wish to explore

4. World State Synchronisation

Two players bring two different world states to every session. Connecting them requires a system that is honest about these differences without breaking either player's world.

The checkpoint model

Multiplayer sessions are anchored to story checkpoints — defined moments in the world's narrative that are broadly compatible across different playthrough states. The game identifies a valid checkpoint window shared by both players and uses this as the session's narrative anchor.

Story connector system

A lightweight narrative bridge is generated for each session — a brief contextual summary that explains, in-world, why these two characters are meeting at this point. This bridge does not overwrite either player's world state. It creates a shared understanding of the current moment without invalidating what came before.

Post-session divergence

After the session ends, both players return to their individual world states. The consequences of the shared session are applied to each player's world independently, adapted to their specific state.

Host world	Session events applied directly — the host's world state was the anchor point
Guest world	Session events adapted to the guest's state — consequences compatible, not identical
Locked areas	Unlocked for both players permanently after a qualifying multiplayer session
NPC memory	NPCs in both worlds remember the meeting — each from their own context
Shared quests	Completed in both worlds; solo-only portions remain open if not yet done

PART III

IDEAS, IMPROVEMENTS & ISSUES

A design-critical analysis — opportunities to push the concept further, improvements to consider, and honest risks to plan around.

A. Expansion Ideas & Opportunities

The Chronicle System — a cross-character living history

IDEA

As players complete character stories, their outcomes are recorded in a shared world chronicle. Future players encounter the aftermath of past playthroughs — not as cutscenes, but as living world changes. A dead character might be spoken of as a legend or a warning. The world accumulates a real history shaped by its players.

Meeting Chapters — multiplayer-exclusive canonical story content

IDEA — FUTURE MULTIPLAYER

A dedicated category of story content that can only be triggered when two specific characters meet in a multiplayer session. These are not side quests — they are canonical story moments that exist only in the space between two characters. Content the world holds in reserve until the right two people find each other. Meeting Chapters would become some of the most talked-about moments in Eugaea's community.

Asynchronous multiplayer — letters, marks, and traces

IDEA — FUTURE MULTIPLAYER

Not all multiplayer needs to be synchronous. An asynchronous layer could allow players to leave messages, marks, or discoveries in the world that other players encounter in their own sessions — warnings at dangerous locations, notes from characters who passed through, traces of decisions made. This gives solo players a feeling that the world is inhabited by others without requiring simultaneous play.

Character perspective events — the same moment, multiple eyes

IDEA

Certain pivotal world events should be designed to be witnessed by multiple characters from different angles. A battle, an assassination, a public revelation — each character experiences it differently, knows different things, and can influence it in different ways. Discovering you were present at the same event as a character you previously played creates profound world depth.

Community-designed playable characters

IDEA — FUTURE COMMUNITY

The community expansion layer could extend to allow fully community-designed playable characters — written, submitted, reviewed, and published as canon characters with their own arcs. This scales the roster without the creator needing to design every character alone and gives the most dedicated community members a path to true authorship.

The dead character as discoverable legacy

IDEA

When a character dies — especially early in a player's journey — their unfinished story should become discoverable content. Other characters might find their journal, encounter people who knew them, discover what they failed to do. A player who loses a beloved character and later stumbles across the ghost of their choices in a completely different playthrough would experience something no other game currently offers.

The Eugaea Atlas — a community living world map

IDEA

An in-game living atlas that grows as community content is added. Players can contribute discovered lore, annotate regions, flag secrets — creating a living reference document that is itself part of the world. The atlas could be a physical object characters find in the game, expanding as the world expands.

Seasonal creator updates — "The World Turns"

IDEA

The creator releases periodic major world updates — not DLC, but world events. A war breaks out. A religion fractures. A new technology destabilises a kingdom. These keep Eugaea feeling alive between community submissions and give the creator a way to steer the world's long-term direction.

B. Design Improvements to Consider

Write the Canon Bible before anything else

IMPROVEMENT

Before writing characters, regions, or story — and long before opening the community toolkit — the creator must produce a Canon Bible: the world's immovable rules. What magic can and cannot do. Which events are fixed. Which characters are protected. What tone is sacrosanct. Every character written without this foundation risks inconsistency. Every community submission without it risks world drift. This document is the bedrock.

Design the character roster as a world coverage matrix

IMPROVEMENT

Each character should be mapped against the world geographically, socially, and thematically before any individual character is written in depth. The roster should collectively cover the full world — no major region, faction, or secret permanently inaccessible. Think of the roster as a key ring: each character is a key. Design the key ring before cutting any keys.

Design the random start system as a mechanic, not a gimmick

IMPROVEMENT

The random character assignment at game start must be meaningful and well-implemented. A player assigned a character who feels wrong for them will disengage early. The system should observe genuine play-style signals — pacing, curiosity, aggression, caution — and match them to a character whose design rewards that approach. Consider playtesting the assignment system independently before building the rest of the game around it.

Define permanent death consequences as first-class design

IMPROVEMENT

Because death is absolute in Eugaea, every character's death must have been designed for. The world must have a response to each character dying — what NPCs say, what changes, what other characters inherit. This is not a system that can be added late. Every character arc must include a designed death state alongside its designed endings. Budget for this explicitly.

Build the AI narrative layer as infrastructure, not feature

IMPROVEMENT

The AI integration — NPC memory, world-state tracking, consequence engine, death response generation — must be designed into the game's architecture from day one. Define the data model for what the world remembers before writing begins. Retrofitting these systems into a completed game is extremely costly.

Character accessibility tiers — not all characters at launch

IMPROVEMENT

Rather than releasing all designed characters at once, consider a tiered release: launch with a core cast of four to six, with others unlocking as the world is explored. This manages scope, allows refinement based on player feedback, and creates natural expansion milestones.

Resolve the visual direction decision early

IMPROVEMENT

The 2D vs 3D decision is not a stylistic preference — it is a foundational scope decision that determines team size, tooling, asset pipeline, community SDK design, and budget. It must be

resolved before pre-production begins. Every week of pre-production spent without this decision being made produces work that may need to be discarded.

C. Risks & Issues to Plan Around

The narrative complexity ceiling

RISK — HIGH

The single greatest challenge of Eugaea is managing the combinatorial explosion of cross-character consequences combined with permanent death. If Character A's actions change the world for Character B, and A then dies, and B inherits A's unfinished story, the number of world states to account for grows exponentially. A consequence design framework — with strict limits on what can affect what — must be one of the first documents produced after the Canon Bible.

Permanent death and player attachment

RISK — HIGH

Permanent death is one of Eugaea's most distinctive features — and its greatest emotional risk. Players who invest deeply in a character and lose them to an avoidable mistake may feel punished rather than immersed. The design must ensure that death is rare, felt, and narratively meaningful — not a frustrating reset. The souls-like precedent shows this is achievable, but it requires deliberate, careful encounter design throughout.

The random start and player satisfaction

RISK — MEDIUM

Assigning a character randomly at game start is a bold opening move. If the assignment system misfires — giving a player a character who feels incompatible with how they naturally play — the first impression of the game will be negative. The system must be robust, tested thoroughly, and ideally include a gentle re-assignment option early enough to feel like a world event rather than a menu option.

The switch imperative as frustration vs. design

RISK — MEDIUM

The mechanism that forces character switching — capture, area locks, skill ceilings — must feel like world logic, not game design showing its seams. If players feel artificially blocked rather than naturally redirected, the switch will feel like punishment. Every switch trigger must be narratively justified and clearly communicated in-world. The player should understand why they need a different perspective, not just that the game is stopping them.

World state synchronisation in multiplayer

RISK — HIGH — FUTURE MULTIPLAYER

Two players will arrive at a session with divergent world states — potentially including characters who have already died in one player's world. The checkpoint model is the proposed solution, but its implementation is technically demanding. This requires a dedicated world-state engine that must be scoped and prototyped early, even if multiplayer ships later.

Community content quality variance

RISK — MEDIUM

The community will produce content of wildly varying quality. Consider a two-tier system: unofficial community content (available but clearly marked as non-canon) and official canon content (creator-reviewed and published). This lets community content exist without polluting the canon world.

Scope management — the concept is larger than any one team

RISK — MEDIUM

Eugaea as described is an ambitious multi-year project. The writing phase must produce a scoped, deliverable world — not a theoretical infinite one. Define the minimum viable Eugaea: the smallest version that is still genuinely Eugaea. Community expansion and multiplayer are future layers, not launch requirements. Build the foundation first and build it well.

NEXT STEPS

Step 1	Resolve the visual direction — 2D retro or 3D AAA
Step 2	Write the Canon Bible — world rules, tone, magic system, protected elements
Step 3	Design the character roster matrix — coverage, death states, and arcs
Step 4	Design and test the random character assignment system
Step 5	Define the consequence framework — what the world remembers and how
Step 6	Define the switch imperative triggers for each character
Step 7	Scope the minimum viable world for pre-production
Step 8	Prototype the AI world-state and NPC memory architecture
Step 9	Architect multiplayer world-state engine (even if multiplayer ships later)